else, as he says, "is just business". In Leanin's *In India*, on the other hand, we see far more individuals photographed. "In the West," he says, "you'll often hear these cliches about India—it's all about the group, the holistic society. I wanted to show it's not that."

Leanin's portraits of migrants, child beauty pageant contestants or of a man holding a knife can be both warm and disconcerting. While there is an unmistakable joy in Rai's images of France, in Leanin's photos there is a greater emphasis on black humour—a man naps on a grave, a mannequin resembles an apparition: "In India, there is a greater acceptance of the physical representations of death. In France, we try to hide it. Here, I think you're more courageous with it all."

Not all of Leanin's pictures are wry and ironic. His photographs of Delhi's crematoriums and cemeteries during the Covid second wave are, at times, harrowing to see. "What struck me is that the even during this very rough period, you felt that same sentiment of common humanity, that same sense of grief, at ceremonies of these different faiths."

In the end, says Leanin, it is that same idea of "a common humanity" which became the driving force behind *To France/ In India*: "In spite of the obvious differences between our countries, Raghu and I wanted to show that our people share these great qualities and a lot of humanity." Hearing Rai delight in Leanin's pictures is, perhaps, evidence that art can help escape our narrow subjectivities. "Have you seen Emmanuel's picture of two girls dancing in Jama Masjid?" he asks us. "I have been there a million times and never experienced something like it. He has captured a 'moment of eternity'." ■

–Shreevatsa Nevatia

EXHIBITION

Beauty Beyond Bresson

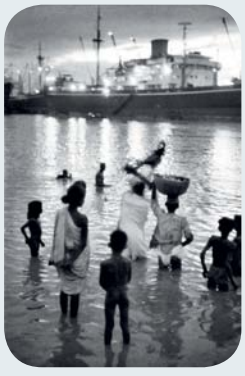
A travelling exhibition shows how several French photographers have made India their muse

One can't overstate how crucial the contribution of France has been to photography. It was in the early 19th century that French inventor Joseph Nicéphore Niépce first made possible the photographic process, and the 20th century, it can be argued, belonged to the French photographer Henri Cartier-Bresson. On view at the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art (KNMA), New Delhi, until June 30, *Convergence: A Panorama of Photography's French Connections in India*, does put on display pictures that French photographers made in India from the mid-19th century to the 1990s (pre-digital), but the exhibition is also testament to French photographic talent that came to fill the gaps between Niépce and Bresson.

Travelling around India in 1956, Marc Riboud, for instance, captured the optimism of a newly-independent nation. "There's poetic humanism in the portraits he produced during the Punjab Suba Movement in 1956, after which the state was divided on the basis of language," says Rahaab Allana, curator, *Convergence*. At least 60 of Riboud's works are being showcased at KNMA, alongside hundreds of other images of the subcontinent, shot by French and European photographers.

Seen as a whole, the exhibition succeeds in bringing together the ordinary and the iconic—a street photo studio in Patna in the 1970s, an ascetic meditating in a temple in 1955, art students in Santiniketan in 1956, a bustling Bombay circa 1940s and Mahatma Gandhi's funeral in 1948. Allana points out that many of the early intrepid photographers were from a military or medical background. They practically "learnt how to use the camera on the go". For example, it was in 1864 that Louis Rousselet bought photographic equipment in Bombay: "Rousselet did considerable work here. He visited the Begum of Bhopal and explored Gujarat, Alwar, Jaipur and Jodhpur. He met Maharaja Sawai Ram Singh II, India's first photographer king. Ram Singh specialised in self-portraits. Thanks to Rousselet's book *India and Its Native Princes* (1876), we now know that they exchanged a lot of notes."





FRENCH LENS (top) 'Mr Louis Rousselet in Court Dress, Bhopal', 1867; Marc Riboud's 'Scene at Ghat', Calcutta, 1956

Grandson of the theatre legend Ebrahim Alkazi, Allana works as a curator at the Alkazi Foundation for the Arts. Passionate about what he calls the "transnational history of South Asian photography", he has spent the past two years working on *Convergence*.

The project began in earnest towards the end of 2020 when Allana received an invitation from Institut Français. Scouring through the archives of five French museums that granted him access to their collections, Allana slowly pieced together a visual history of India. Interested in "the bilateralism between the known and unknown, the acknowledged and unacknowledged", he says, "I did not want to take a majoritarian view. The idea was to tell the story through all those who were present, both celebrated photographers and anonymous ones."

Having already enjoyed a successful run in cities like Ahmedabad, Bengaluru and Chennai, *Convergence*, a part of the Bonjour India 2022 festival, is expected to travel to Mumbai later this year. ■

– Shaikh Ayaz